First Train Arrives The High Level Bridge
June 1913

A Team Effort

While it's difficult to imagine our Legislature looking any other way, in the beginning it was hard to agree on a design!

Architect Edward Hopkins presented the first plans, but they were rejected for being too similar to the British Columbia Legislature. In 1907, A.M. Jeffers arrived from Rhode Island and was appointed Alberta's provincial architect. His design, with its classical details, won the approval of the Minister of Public Works.

Jeffers led most of the construction until he resigned in 1912. Richard Blakey, the next provincial architect, oversaw its completion.

From architects to tradespeople, this building reflects the vision and effort of many Albertans working together.

Alberta Provincial Archives

Alberta's Potential

For more than 100 years, the Legislature Building has welcomed and served Albertans and their elected leaders. It was built to be more than a meeting place. Its construction showcased Alberta's strength to its citizens and the rest of Canada.

Legislature Building under construction, Edmonton, Alberta, 1910.

Inspired by the architectural tradition known as *Beaux Arts*, this French style draws on themes from ancient Greece, the birthplace of Athenian democracy. Its beauty and design are a source of pride for our province. They remind Albertans of the justice, equality, representation, and freedom that democracy promises.

Notice the tall columns and large central dome - key features borrowed from ancient Greece and Rome. They symbolize stability, power, and importance. Other classical details include the symmetrical shape, decorative carvings, and flat roof.

The architects chose Calgary sandstone, Manitoba Tyndall stone, and granite from Vancouver Island as building materials. These strong Canadian stones reflect Alberta's resilience and will last for generations.

Parliament Building under construction

Legislature Grounds, 1915

Spot the Difference

Beaux-Arts architecture was popular in the United States of America from 1890 to 1930. Many state capitols were designed in this style, becoming a symbol of prosperity and economic strength.

While gathering ideas for the design of the Legislature, Alberta's first Premier, Alexander Rutherford, visited the Minnesota State Capitol in St. Paul. He was impressed by the building and wanted the Legislature to reflect a similar style. In the end, the design of the Alberta Legislature was very similar to this American building.

Which design details of the Legislature catch your eye, and what do they tell you about Alberta?

Opening the Doors to Albertans

Excited for the new Legislature Building, occupants were ready to move in before construction was finished. The Provincial Library, now known as the Alberta Legislature Library, moved in first in 1911. Members of the Legislative Assembly followed soon after. Although the official opening would come later in 1912, there was keen interest for the First Session in the building. The *Edmonton Capital* newspaper reported people forcing their way through the halls, peeking through the windows, and keeping the rotunda "packed to suffocation."

Unfortunately, issues arose shortly after moving in. The Legislature Building did not have enough offices for all the members. The planners designed the Legislature for the 1907 Assembly, which only had 25 MLAs. By 1911, the number had grown to 41 members. The original design left no room for additions, causing members to shuffle between nearby buildings until the Bowker Building was constructed in 1931.

Despite the growing pains, the Legislature Building has welcomed Albertans through its doors ever since.

Interior of Alberta Legislature, ca. 1910-1913.

Opening of Legislature Building, 1926.

Celebrations in honour of the Silver Jubilee of King George V and Queen Mary, held in Edmonton. May 6, 1935.

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Top image: Provincial News CO., Edmonton, Alberta.
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Wired for Sound

When members started working in the Chamber, they quickly noticed a problem. No one could hear each other clearly. Many creative solutions were suggested. Perhaps the members could deliver each speech into a megaphone or move their chairs closer and sit in a circle?

In 1911, the Chamber was literally "wired for sound." Wire clotheslines were "criss-crossed" throughout the room, then draped with "white, light material." The belief was the fabric would muffle outside sounds and direct the voices of the Assembly.

The *Edmonton Journal* had this to say of the laundry-based solution: "It makes the affected fine appearance of the chamber singularly ridiculous. Possibly it improves the acoustics, but not so appreciably as to make hearing easy."

A permanent solution arrived in 1965, when a sound system was installed, ensuring every member could be heard.

Interior of the Alberta Legislature, ca. 1910-1913.

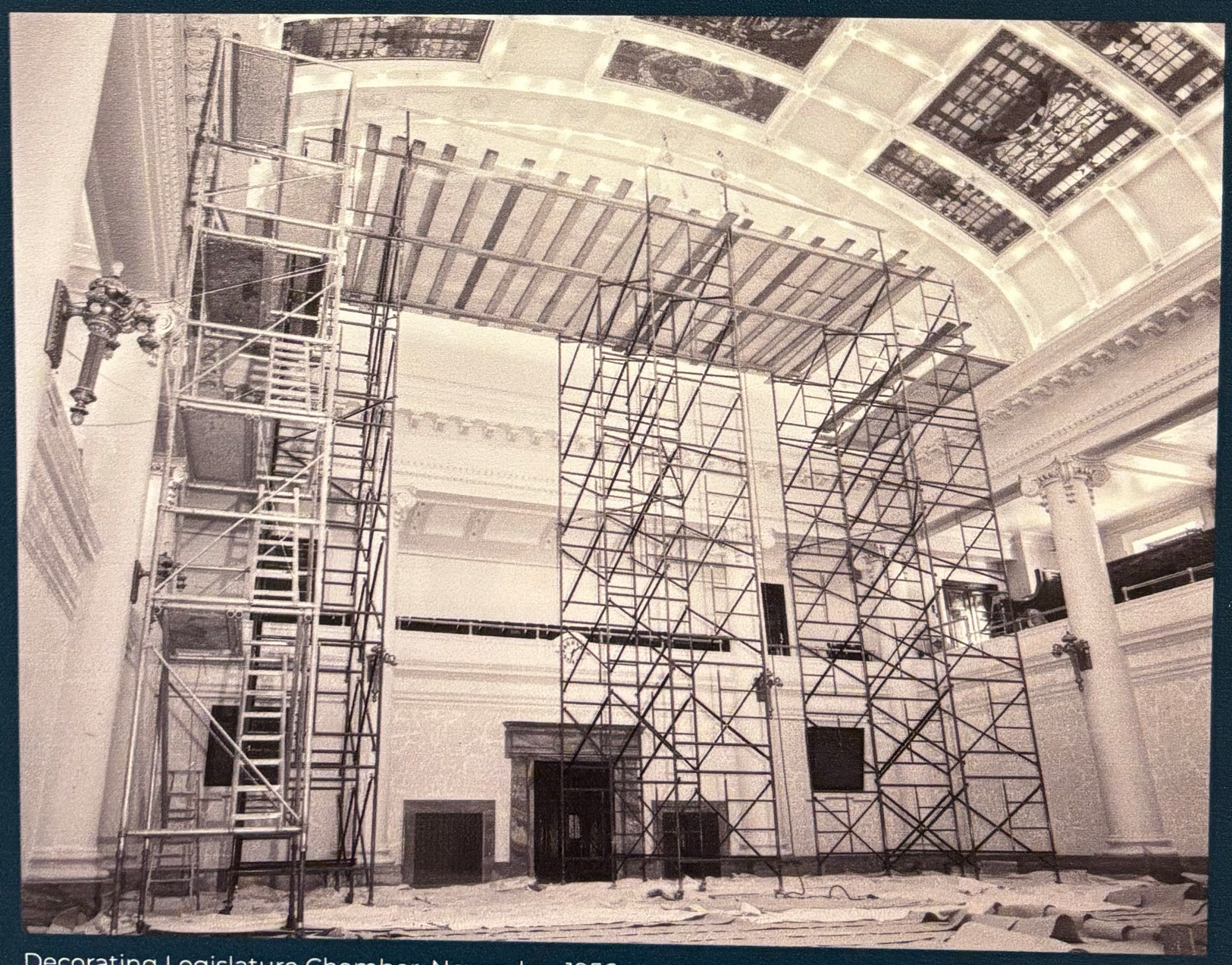
Governing in a Construction Zone

> *"The first incident was a partial collapse of the building. Sounds rather alarming."*

That's how the *Calgary Herald* started a news story on January 25, 1912. This dramatic report detailed how a newly constructed pillar beside the Speaker's dais had begun to settle, causing the plaster to crack. It eventually gave way with a loud crack and the pieces fell to the ground next to the Premier's chair during session.

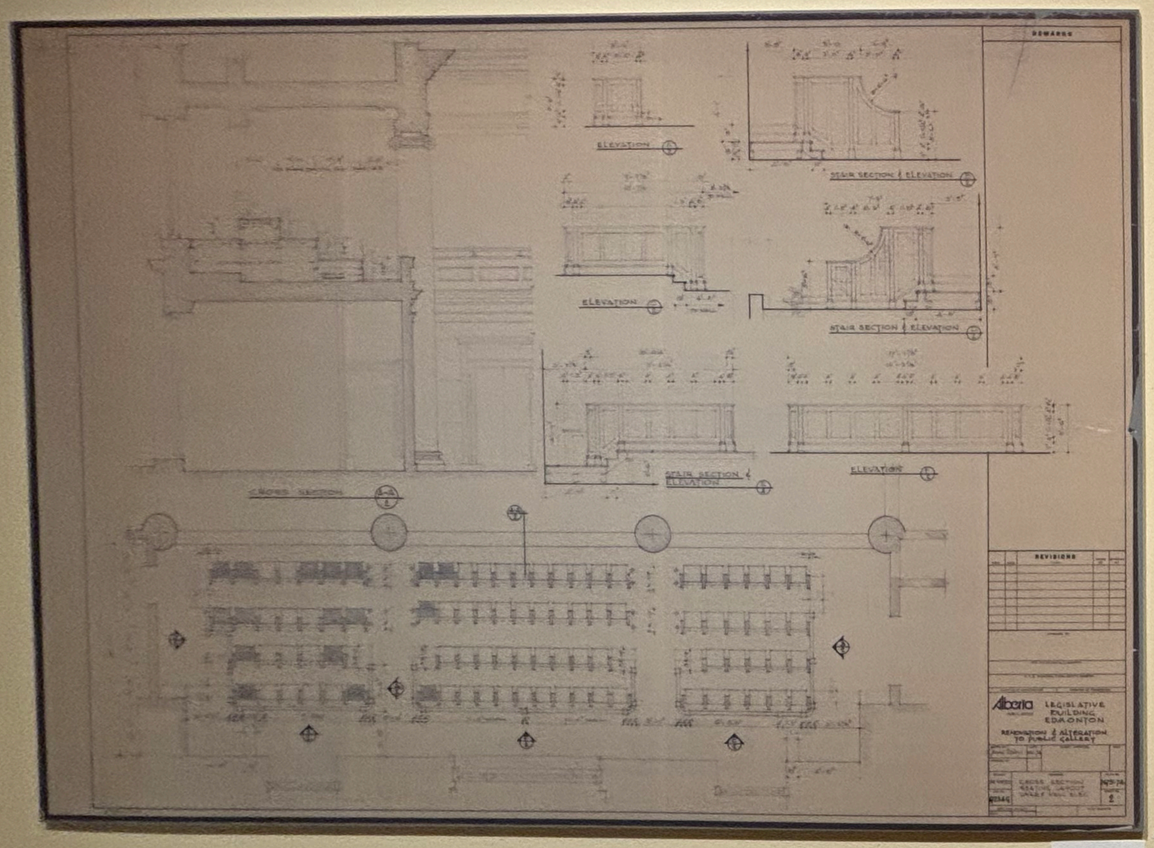
The reporter carried on with their theatrical retelling, writing, "some dark looks were cast at the opposition members to see if it was any diabolical plot on their part to overwhelm the government."

The plaster would be repaired in the coming days.



Decorating Legislature Chamber, November 1956.

Photo Credit:
Provincial Archives of Alberta, PA43.3.



Alberta Legislature Chamber awaiting repairs, December 1966.

Provincial Archives of Alberta, A2998.2081

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3. Provincial Archives of Alberta, A2998.

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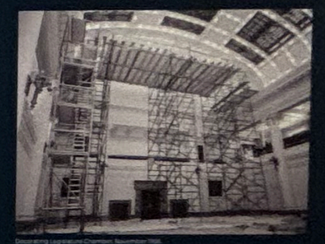

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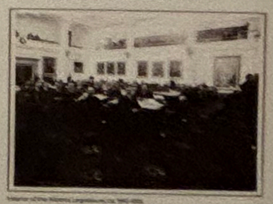

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Ceremonies and Events

Beyond politics and lawmaking, the Alberta Legislature is a space for community. Its grand spaces welcome locals, visitors, and dignitaries for ceremonies and celebrations. Every year, thousands gather on the grounds for Canada Day or major events like the 2005 royal visit. Each November, the rotunda fills with music and ceremony to honour the life of Louis Riel and celebrate Métis culture.

Lieutenant-Governor John Bowen arriving for levee at the Legislature Building, 1948.

For years, the Legislature hosted the Lieutenant Governor's New Year's Levee. This event allows everyday Albertans to meet their royal representative. Today, this open house happens at Government House, the former official residence of the Lieutenant Governor.

Sombre occasions are also marked at the Legislature. In 1934, a group of government employees observed two minutes of silence during the first Remembrance Day ceremony held in the rotunda. In 1937, the Legislature held Alberta's first state funeral after the death of the Honourable Colonel Philip C. H. Primrose, Lieutenant Governor of Alberta.

New Year's wishes at annual levee in the Legislature Building, 1949.

Prince of Wales at the Legislature Building, 1927.

Party Time!

Important days at the Legislature became an opportunity for members of Edmonton's high society to wear their finest! Events at the Legislature were popular social outings. Banquets and balls have been part of the building's calendar since the 1912 opening celebration.

The *Edmonton Journal* described the opening of the 1913 legislative session: "Ladies gaily attired; flowers prettily arranged; aides-de-camp in dress uniforms, and legislators endeavoring (sic) to look interested in a scene in which most of them are nervous..."

Imagine orchestral music echoing off the marble as nearly 200 revellers danced the night away. In January 1928, the Civil Service Association's new social committee kicked off the year with a dance in the rotunda of the Legislature!

Formal reception at the 11th opening of the Alberta Legislature, 1949.

Photo Credit:
City of Edmonton Archives EA-600-2071e.